

agent at a chain preparer like H&R Block; if possible, ask to work with one. Preparers usually file your return electronically, so if you're due a refund you will get it faster than you would if you mailed in your return.

Finally, no matter who you have fill out your forms, look over the forms carefully. *You* are responsible for making sure all the information on your return is true and correct. Take the time to really read it before you sign and submit it.

↓ FINANCIAL CRAMMING

- **Figure out your marginal tax bracket. This is important to know. See Figure 9–1.**
- **Fill out your tax forms as soon as possible, but not too soon. If you're owed a refund, file right away; the quicker you mail in your forms, the faster you'll get your check. If you owe money to the IRS, file in early April so you can hang on to your cash as long as possible.**
- **If you're expecting a refund, file electronically and sign up to have your refund deposited directly into your bank account. Your money will arrive within ten days rather than the six to eight weeks it takes if you file by mail.**
- **If you received a big refund from the IRS, fill out a new W-4 form to adjust your withholding. Since the IRS doesn't pay you interest on the money you overpay during the year, you're better off keeping this money in a bank account or money market fund.**
- **If you owe the IRS money but you can't afford to pay, send in your return along with whatever payment you can afford by April 15 anyway and set up an installment plan. You'll have to pay a penalty, but it won't be as stiff as the penalty for late filing.**
- **Take full advantage of the tax credits available to you if you have children or educational expenses, as described**